

investigation GUJARAT

THE SCHEDULED

■ By Uday Mahurkar in Kadana, Santrampur

Ever since the Constitution came into force in January 1950, it has been under pressure from political parties wanting to dilute some of its fundamental objectives in their blinkered pursuit of votes. One constitutional weapon meant for social and economic uplift of backward classes that has been widely misused is caste-based reservation. Today, it has become a tool in the hands of vote-hungry politicians to stretch it as much as they can and satisfy numerically powerful and vocal caste groups. While much has been going on in the name of reservation all over the country, what has been happening in certain parts of central Gujarat over the past three decades really takes the cake.

An INDIA TODAY investigation reveals that lakhs of low caste Kshatriyas who fall in the OBC category have been passing off as Scheduled Tribes (ST) and pocketing the benefits of reservation in Panchmahal and Vadodra districts of central Gujarat. They have grabbed thousands of ST jobs at the cost of genuine tribals along with the benefits of tribal welfare schemes. This is now coming in the way of delimitation of parliamentary seats as well. Ironically, a reserved tribal seat in Navsari district is about to get dereserved just because it is the turn of Santrampur seat of Panchmahal district—which has the maximum number of fake tribals—to get reserved. Kadana tehsil in Santrampur constituency had less than three per cent tribals in the 1971 census which rose to 73 per cent in the 2001 census as the Kshatriyas had been registering themselves as tribals.



"This fraud has gone on for long because genuine tribals do not have powerful leaders."

GANGJIBHAI TRIBAL, VILLAGE KHEDEPA



To justify their changed status, many claim that their elders were illiterate and not knowing they were tribals had failed to get themselves registered under the reserved category in government records. But the stark difference in their and the tribal way of life gives them away. While the

Kshatriyas keep swords or daggers at home, tribals keep bows and arrows. A Kshatriya wedding takes place during the night and is similar to a normal Hindu marriage while a tribal wedding takes place during daytime and the son-in-law of the person whose daughter or son is getting married plays the role of a priest. Even the manner in which they speak Gujarati is different for both the groups. Saburbhai Katara, a tribal who is opposing the hijacking of tribal rights by non-tribals says: "This is the worst fraud to be committed on the Indian